

Science Foundation (NSF) to break these silos. In recent years, private players have stepped in to play the role of facilitators—IBM India recently brought together two great Indian institutions separated by only a few hundred miles, C-DAC in Pune and IIT-Bombay to set up an Open Source Software Resource Centre. Microsoft Research India hosts researchers from the Indian Institute of Science and several of the IITs and government labs in a major initiative to build tools for resource-poor Indian languages.

Association with world-class private companies also acts as a credible signal of the quality of Indian public-sector research. More than the plethora of domestic awards, relationships with world-class names bring an accreditation of quality. The technology fund of TeNet, the in-house incubator at IIT Madras and investor in startups like Midas Communication Technologies, includes globally renowned investors, including Google. Finally, stronger commercial relationships with the private sector will help remunerate scientists fully, and perhaps stem an ongoing flight of talent purely towards the private sector.

Nor is the idea of private-sector led catalysis of the public sector purely a 'science' story. A hopeful trend is the competition between India's states to attract private capital, whether foreign or indigenous. This takes a useful page out of neighbour China's reform playbook. There, provinces and cities have long competed for access to technology and capital from foreign direct investors. Rather than any race-to-the-bottom, this has resulted in provinces stepping up their game and providing services that are complements to those provided by the private investors. The ensuing bargaining game between public and private entities helps ensure the best use of what each party brings to the development table.

Fortunately, in India, instances of such private sector-induced catalysis arise daily. Cardiologist Devi Shetty's health city and his preceding efforts—in health care delivery, health insurance for penurious folks, etc.—have judiciously leveraged cooperation from the Karnataka state Government and ensured that some of the latter's state-hospitals are better utilised.

In March, the Bangalore-based Team-Lease Services and the Rajasthan state Government organised a Vishal Rozgar Mela in Jaipur that saw the participation from over 35,000 job aspirants, 90 employers, and 15

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assessment and training companies. The event's agenda included skill assessment sessions for potential employees, counselling sessions on 'skill repair' and registration for job training programmes. That is, TeamLease leveraged the Rajasthan Government's reach to help bring underemployed youth into the economic mainstream, in a way that benefits the state exchequer.

These are early days, and no one should erroneously think of these private sector activities as a substitute for a revitalised public sector. But private entrepreneurs can serve as catalysts to reignite enthusiasm in moribund parts of the Indian state. Making some of these initiatives bottom-up could help, with incentives for individual scientists, academics and bureaucrats to engage with private players. For example, CSIR has announced that 40 per cent of fees from corporate R&D projects will be shared among scientists. It will also allow some key scientists to join private sector boards of directors.

Jawaharlal Nehru, doyen of both the public sector and of Indian science, once commented, "The future belongs to science and those who make friends with science." I am sure he would not have begrudged the public sector a gentle nudge from its private counterpart to realise the desired future.

Smart Thinking

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